Local SEO Masterclass

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**Ranking a Local Google ...**

Introduction to Local SEO

NAP Consistency + Map Emb...

Getting ONLY 5 Star Reviews f...

Getting a Google My Busines...

GMB Location + Direction Ma...

**Rank and Rent (Organic S...**

Introduction to Rank and Rents

Setting up a Rank and Rent

Ranking your Rank and Rent

Pricing your Rank and Rent

Pitching Rank and Rents

**Local SEO for Beginners (...**

Introduction

Module 1: Introduction to Loc...

Module 2: Setting Up Your Go...

# Module 7: Key Local SEO Ranking Factors

**Overview:** At this point, you have the fundamentals in place: a Google Business Profile, a solid website with on-page optimization, and even schema. Module 7 zooms out to discuss the **major factors influencing local rankings** – essentially, a summary of what Google's algorithm looks at for local search. Understanding these factors will help you prioritize ongoing work and troubleshoot if rankings aren't improving. We'll cover the top factors like **Google category selection, NAP consistency, citations, backlinks, reviews, and proximity**. Some of these we have addressed (or will address in upcoming modules), but here we tie them together so you have a clear mental checklist of what affects local SEO success. Consider this a knowledge module to reinforce why each piece of your campaign matters.

**Lessons:**

1. **Google My Business Category & Info** – One of the *strongest* factors is having the proper **category** on your Google Business Profile. We reiterate: ensure you chose the most accurate primary category (and add secondary categories if relevant). A wrong category can severely limit visibility (e.g., an electrician mis-categorized as "Home Services" instead of "Electrician" will struggle to rank for electrician searches). Also, completeness of your GMB info (we did this in Module 2) is a factor – Google trusts profiles that are fully filled out and regularly updated.

2. **NAP Consistency & Citations** – Consistent Name, Address, Phone across all online platforms is critical. Inconsistent citations (like slight name differences or old addresses) can confuse Google and weaken your local rankings. We explain that **citations** (mentions of your NAP on other websites, e.g.



Module 4: Local Keyword Res…

Module 5: On-Page SEO for Y…

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Module 8: Building Citations

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module, but as a factor: *more high-quality citations = stronger local SEO*. Make sure you have a single, standardized NAP that you use everywhere.

3. **Backlinks and Domain Authority** – Even for local SEO, traditional SEO factors like **backlinks** (other sites linking to yours) carry a lot of weight. In fact, backlinks are consistently cited among Google's top 3 ranking factors. A local business's website with many **quality, relevant backlinks** will generally outrank one with few or poor backlinks. We clarify that not all backlinks are equal – local links from, say, a Chamber of Commerce or a local newspaper might be especially valuable. Building a strong backlink profile will be covered in Module 11. Also, the overall **Domain Authority** of your site (a metric that approximates trust/quality based on backlinks, content, etc.) matters. Higher authority sites tend to rank better, which is why link building and content are ongoing needs.

4. **User Reviews & Ratings** – **Review signals** play a big role in local rankings. Businesses with a higher quantity of positive reviews (especially on Google, but also on other platforms) often see a boost. The **review velocity** (how frequently you get new reviews) and diversity (reviews on multiple sites) also matter. We highlight that, beyond pure ranking, reviews hugely impact click-through (people are more likely to choose a 4.8-star business than a 3.5-star one). So, obtaining and maintaining good reviews is both an SEO and a conversion factor. We'll have a full module on reviews (Module 10).

5. **Proximity & Location Factors** – Some factors are not in your control but are worth understanding. Google heavily considers the **searcher's proximity to the business** (or the centroid of the searched area). This means even a perfectly optimized business might not show up for someone across town if there are nearer competitors. Additionally, the physical address's relation to the city center can influence rankings (historically businesses closer to "downtown" sometimes ranked higher, though this is less rigid now). While you can't move the business for SEO, you *can* ensure

6. **On-Page Signals (Content & Keywords)** – We reaffirm that your website's content needs to align with your targeted keywords and location. Google determines whether your site contains the city name, relevant services, etc., especially in important areas like title tags and headings. You should be in good shape since you addressed this in Module 5. But remember, creating additional localized content (like blog posts about local topics or landing pages for sub-areas) can further boost relevance.

7. **Behavioral Signals and Engagement** – Lastly, a more subtle factor: how users interact with your listings. If many people click your listing (high click-through rate) or call/get directions (Google tracks actions on your GMB), it can signal that your result is valuable, potentially boosting it. Likewise, keeping users engaged on your site (low bounce rate, decent time on site) might indirectly help. The core of this is: a well-optimized listing and website that truly serve user needs will naturally generate positive engagement signals, which feeds back into better ranking.

**Implementation Steps:**

- **Audit Your Consistency:** Do a quick self-audit using the factors above. Verify your Google Business Profile category and info are correct (change if needed). Search for your business name online and see if any listings (Yelp, old Yellow Pages, etc.) show outdated info – make a note to fix those (we'll tackle citations next).

- **Check Your Backlink Profile:** Use a tool like the free version of Moz Link Explorer or Ahrefs (they often have trial accounts) to see how many backlinks your site has and from where. Note if competitors have notable backlinks that you don't. This will inform your link-building efforts.

- **Assess Reviews:** Look at your current Google rating and number of reviews. Also check Facebook, Yelp, or industry-specific sites. Compare with a couple of local competitors. If you're lagging, it's a clear sign you should prioritize a review-gathering strategy (coming in Module 10).



be a challenge). Understanding this helps set realistic expectations and focus efforts on factors you *can* control (like citations, content, links, reviews).

- **Prioritize Next Steps:** With this big-picture knowledge, you can prioritize your upcoming work. Generally, if we rank the controllable factors: 1) **Google Profile optimization** (done), 2) **Citations consistency/quality**, 3) **Reviews**, 4) **Backlinks/content**, 5) **On-page SEO** (done). So, ensure you dedicate time to citation building, review generation, and link outreach in the coming weeks – these will give the business the competitive edge in local rankings.

**Milestone:** *By the end of Module 7, you will have a solid understanding of the primary factors that affect local search rankings.* You'll also have evaluated where your project stands on each factor. This knowledge equips you to be a smarter SEO – you can explain to clients **why** certain steps (like building citations or getting reviews) are necessary, and you can better diagnose issues if the site isn't ranking (e.g., "We need more quality backlinks to compete in this market"). Essentially, you now know what levers to pull to boost a local site's visibility, and you're ready to act on the most important ones.